THE COMPLETE GUIDE TO TANK GIRL

AFTER 28 YEARS OF COMICS, ONE HOLLYWOOD CULT HIT AND INFINITE ANARCHY, TANK GIRL IS STILL GOING STRONG…

It's 1988. Margaret Thatcher has just become the longest serving prime minister of the century, the first Comic Relief event has been held, Wimbledon have won the FA Cup, and over in Australia kangaroos have moved on from destroying crops to snogging farmers and burning their kids.

Or at least they had in the post-apocalyptic wasteland created by young writer Alan Martin and pre-Gorillaz-fame punk artist Jamie Hewlett; a futuristic and anarchic setting for a comic called *Tank Girl*. The Iron Lady had been famously photographed in a tank just two years previously, but the two Sussex lads unveiled an enemy of the establishment that would have an even greater iconic legacy.

"The late, great 2000 AD artist Brett Ewins came to our art college in Worthing and gave us a lecture on working in comics," explains Martin. "We gave him a copy of our home-made fanzine Atom Tan, which he took away with him. In the fanzine was a one-page advert for a character named Tank Girl that Jamie and I had slammed together to fill a page. A year later, Brett was preparing to launch *Deadline* – a new comics/media/music magazine, that he had created with fellow artist Steve Dillon – and he asked us to expand the *Tank Girl* advert into a full strip. Brett's character Johnny Nemo was originally slated as the figurehead of the magazine, but as soon as they saw Jamie's art for the first story, they decided to put *Tank Girl* on the front cover of the first issue."

Rebecca Buck, the eponymous rager who never goes by her real name, drives a tank. Her home is her tank. Her life is her tank. All hail the tank. Her bald head, stompy boots and foul-mouthed character grabbed a place in pop-culture history as the figurehead of the notorious Riot Grrrl movement – ie the backlash to the backlash against feminism that embraced queer theory and punk ideology.

The Eighties are often described as a boom time for alternative comics in the United Kingdom, but in truth, adult comics had been around for a while, and these years are mostly notable for producing a newer, younger and more diverse audience. This could only be seen as a success within the industry.

This was the perfect breeding ground for *Deadline*, a brand new counterculture magazine focused on comics and indie music for the angry youths. And when it came to deciding what strips should feature in the first issue, there was no doubting *Tank Girl*'s rightful place.

"When I worked with Jamie on the original *Deadline* stories, there was very little planning," Martin recounts, "usually nothing more than a drunken conversation in a pub – and we would come up with stupid ideas while we simultaneously constructed the script and artwork. These days, because I'm working remotely with artists all around the globe, the production has to be much more traditional, with me writing scripts and sending them out. Within that, we still manage to be pretty stupid though."

Tank Girl comics have been published regularly through the decades with a small break following a slightly disastrous film adaptation, always written by Martin and hosting a pantheon of Britain's greatest artists. Drawing on surrealist techniques – cut-up, stream of consciousness, metafiction, collage – and blending in well with the DIY-zines that were the height of fashion in the early Nineties, it remains a very different kind of comic from the majority of graphic novels on bookshop shelves.

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Tank Girl's most recent exploits can be found in *Solid State Tank Girl*, drawn by Warwick Johnson-Cadwell, and her newest adventure with Brett Parsons, *Two Girls One Tank*, is coming soon.

"I've been a fan since I was at art college, a few years behind Hewlett and Martin at Northbrook College of Art, Worthing," recalls Johnson-Cadwell. "I didn't know them then, but I did love a comic full of guns, swears and nasty behaviour: *Deadline*."

"I first discovered *Tank Girl* when I was around 12 years old, I think," adds Parson. "I grew up near a comic-book museum called the Words and Pictures Museum, owned by Kevin Eastman of [*Teenage Mutant*] *Ninja Turtles/Heavy Metal*. It must have been just before the release of the *Tank Girl* movie, and the museum was having an exhibit of all the artwork from the original comics. From then on I've been hooked! *Tank Girl* and Jamie Hewlett's work has been a huge influence on me."

Ah yes, the movie. A sore spot for many a *Tank Girl* fan, there is no denying that the 1995 film starring Lori Petty brought the character even greater levels of infamy. Petty perfectly embodied Tank Girl, looking almost exactly like Gwen Stefani a full six months before Stefani hung up her all-American apparel in favour of rocking her now signature look. No Doubt on the coincidence there as Stefani also auditioned for the role of Rebecca Buck, but who could blame her?

The film is, sadly, pretty unanimously panned as trash, only loosely based on the comic and mostly remembered for starring Ice-T as a kangaroo. The cast, however, is downright phenomenal, with Petty and Ice-T joined by Naomi Watts, Malcolm McDowell, Ann Cusack and Iggy Pop.

And the soundtrack was banging, assembled by Courtney Love and featuring Björk, Portishead and Magnificent Bastards amongst others. Major plot gaps led to some last-minute animated sequences produced by Hewlett – a must-see for all Gorillaz fans.

Alas, the film tanked, and both Martin and Hewlett have spoken frequently about their unhappiness with an adaptation that simply didn't grasp the disrupted and fragmented nature of the strips. But in the years that followed, *Tank Girl* has become a genuine cult hit with all-new credentials. The book *Cult Cinema* even lists *Tank Girl* as "a 'real' feminist cult film", which isn't bad going for a film that at the last minute had the studio nix a post-coital scene incorporating a prosthetic kangaroo penis.

"The film is a strange beast," Martin concedes. "I hate it because of its appalling script – it looks great, it's just the dialogue that makes me cringe – but it has brought a whole new generation of fans to the comics.